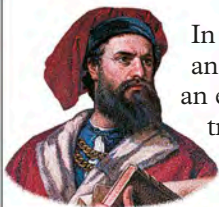




MARCO POLO



In 1271 a merchant named Marco Polo and his family set off from Venice on an extraordinary journey to China. They traveled along the Silk Road, an important trading route between Europe and the Far East. Merchants had been using the route for more than 1,700 years before

the Polos, but they were the first Europeans to travel its whole length. In an age when there were no planes, trains, coaches, or cars, they crossed thousands of miles of mountains, deserts, and plains on foot, horseback, and even on camels. Their journey to China took them more than three years. The Silk Road could be very dangerous and the traders were sometimes attacked by bandits. Because of this threat, they traveled together in groups.

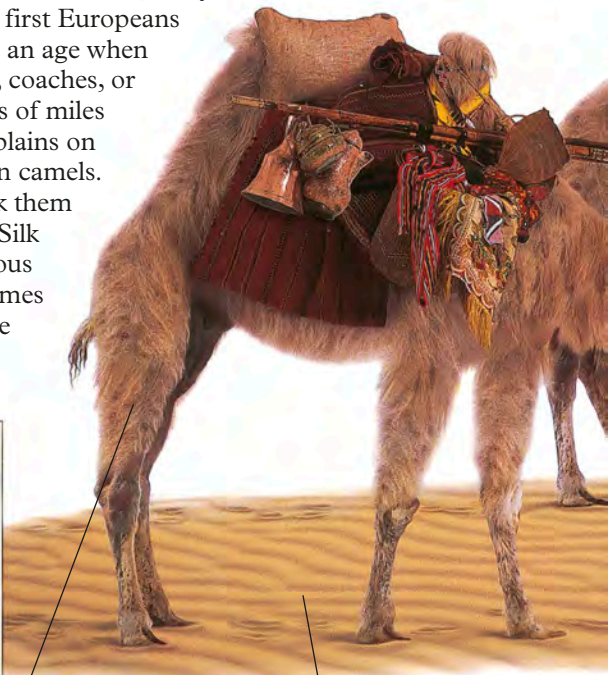


Wealthy traders

Venice was the most important port in Europe. Its merchants traveled by sea and land to bring back goods from the East to sell to other towns in Europe.

Making a trade

The Venetian merchants exchanged jewels, silver, and gold for goods from the East that were highly valued in Europe. These included spices, silks, porcelain or "china," and fine carpets.



Camels were used by merchants when crossing the desert regions of central Asia. Unlike horses, they were able to travel long distances without needing water.

Besides the barren deserts, merchants traveling on the Silk Road had to climb over extreme mountain ranges and cross flooded rivers.

